

J-RPG Speedrun Guantlet

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Purpose of this project

Undertale is one of the most influential games within the Japanese Role-Playing Game (J-RPG) genre. While known for its masterful execution of its story, music, and atmosphere, Undertale is also widely known for accidentally becoming one of the most popular titles in the speedrunning community thanks to a few oversights made in the game design. This project aims to develop its own short J-RPG world that is distinct from Undertale. Its main goal is to complete the game within the shortest amount of time possible. By learning how Undertale glitches and exploits work within Undertale's GameMaker engine, they will be implemented in this project for players to use to save time.

Goals and features

The project will achieve the following goals:

- Feature a fully completed J-RPG title. This would include 4 rooms, 1-3 enemy encounters, and a boss fight at the end. Without the use of glitches, this experience aims to be around 8 mins.
- Implement several ways to save time using skillful in-game mechanics and Undertale exploits.
- Offer several quality-of-life features that inform and assist speed runners. An example is an in-game timer.

The project will achieve these goals by offering the following features:

- Essential game systems and features: framerate management, input handling, audio system, graphics system, collision detection, camera system, physics system, screen edge handling, a scene handling system, custom sprites, and asset management.
- J-RPG elements: overworld level, dialogue system, battle system, and inventory system. The player would pick up an item that would act like Undertale's punch card item, where using the item would force the player to regain movement, even in scenarios where they are not intended to. This leaves several exploits that can be leveraged to save time.

- Enemy encounters and boss fights would feature a combo system that is equivalent to Undertale's burnt pan weapon. A player could land a critical attack if performed perfectly allowing the player to potentially defeat the boss in fewer turns. This allows skill expression to save time without the use of glitches and exploits.
- Undertale wrong warps are performed by regaining movement during a screen transition and have the benefit of moving the player to the next room's default origin position rather than the entrance position. By purposely implementing wrong warps, the rooms would be developed in a way to give players a significant advantage if performed.

Why this project is important

Undertale's neutral speedrun category is incredibly complex and mechanically difficult to obtain a satisfying completion time. It offers several glitches and exploits to be used to save minutes, which allows a sub-hour completion time to be possible. This project would be a showcase of Undertale's exploits in its isolation.

Many would consider the neutral category incredibly intimidating to learn. This project would offer new and experienced speed runners a way to learn and practice these glitches in a well-defined, condensed, and isolated 5-10 minute experience. With offering a significantly shorter experience, this helps ease new speed runners into learning the full Undertale neutral category. With the reduced time commitment, resets would be less frustrating, and glitches would be practiced at a faster pace.

Previous work and distinctiveness

Deltatraveler: A Deltarune fan game that has the protagonists of Deltarune visit other game worlds like Undertale, Earthbound, and GG!Underfell. In the Earthbound segment of the game, the developer added the punch card as a reference to Undertale speedrunning. This punch card was implemented the exact same way as Undertale's punch card allowing for several Undertale exploits to be used to wrong warp and skip cutscenes. This work shows that the behavior is possible to implement in other engines other than Undertale's because Deltatraveler was made in Unity rather than GameMaker. This project differentiates from Deltatraveler by focusing entirely on speedrunning rather than its story.

OceanBagel's Undertale Speedrunning Guide: OceanBagel is a notable person in the Undertale Speedrunning community due to his deep technical knowledge of Undertale. He developed a well-documented guide of how to speedrun Undertale, which contains in-depth explanations of how and why Undertale glitches and exploits work. This project

differs from this guide by offering a playable space other than Undertale to learn and practice Undertale exploits.

Undertale Practice Mod: An Undertale Mod made for the purpose of practicing specific segments for Undertale speedrunning. It includes features like save-stating and debug mode features to give the player useful information like world position, global.interact value, and step counts. This mod provides an excellent source of information about how Undertale's systems work. This project differentiates from this mod by being its own game with its own short story, UI elements, and features.

Team qualifications

I am qualified to achieve this project in the allotted time. Here are my qualifications:

- As a developer of a previous game project named "Asgore Genocide Fight," I have developed a video game prototype that utilizes a battle system that exactly mimics Undertale.
- As a current speedrunner of Undertale that holds top 100 in both genocide and neutral glitched categories, I have good knowledge and experience with Undertale's exploits to implement and test them in this project.
- As one of the developers of a team project called "BudgetBuddy," I am qualified to potentially develop a web application if it is needed in this project.

References

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